

The Decision Rights & Bottleneck Matrix

How SME Founders Delegate Authority Without Losing Quality Control

1. THE CORE RULE

Traditional delegation tells a team member to **do** a task. Decision rights tell a team member **where their authority ends**. If a decision costs less than your hourly rate to fix, your team should never wait for your sign-off.

2. THE 4-TIER DECISION MATRIX

Tier	Category	Example Scenarios	Action Rule	Automation / System Fix
1	Autonomous	SaaS tools < \$100/mo, client refunds < \$250, re-sending proposals	Team acts independently. No approval or notification needed.	Pre-approved corporate card thresholds; automated client portal rules.
2	Notify After	Booking travel, shifting schedules < 3 days, team re-allocations	Team acts immediately, then sends a 1-line async update.	Automated Slack/Teams webhook alert sent to owner after action.
3	1-Click Pre-Approve	Scope additions > \$1,000, out-of-contract discounts, SOW edits	Team drafts solution & proposal. Owner gives 1-click sign-off.	AI agent drafts reply + quote; owner clicks Approve in Slack.
4	Owner Call	Annual budgets, key hires/fires, equity/strategy shifts	Owner leads. Synchronous review or meeting required.	Calendar block; zero automated by pass.

3. THE 4-STEP IMPLEMENTATION

1. Current vs. Intended Owner

Name who currently makes the call vs. who should make it.

2. Authority Boundary

Define exact numerical or dollar limits (e.g., discounts up to 5% or \$1,000).

3. Escalation Triggers

Name the non-negotiable scenarios that must route to you (e.g., gross margin < 40%).

4. Fallback Mechanism

Set a 24-hour backup rule so work never stalls if a decision-maker is away.